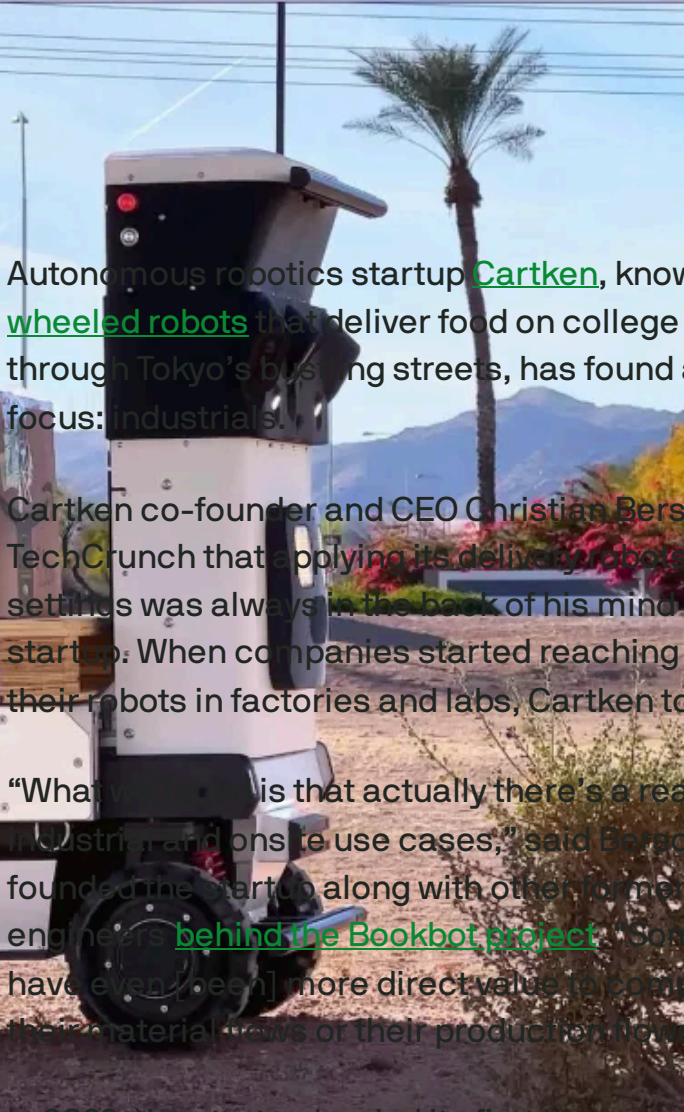




ROBOTICS



Why Cartken pivoted its focus from last-mile delivery to industrial robots



Autonomous robotics startup [Cartken](#), known for its [six-wheeled robots](#) that deliver food on college campuses and through Tokyo's bustling streets, has found a new area of focus: [industrials](#).

Cartken co-founder and CEO Christian Bersch told TechCrunch that applying its delivery robots to industrial settings was always in the back of his mind as they built the startup. When companies started reaching out about using their robots in factories and labs, Cartken took a closer look.

"What we realized is that actually there's a real big need in industrial and onsite use cases," said Bersch, who co-founded the startup along with other former Google engineers [behind the Bookbot project](#). "Sometimes there have even been more direct value to companies optimizing their material flows or their production flows."

In 2023, the startup landed its first big industrial customer, German manufacturing company ZF Lifetec. Initially, ZF Lifetec used its existing delivery robots, called the Cartken Courier, which can hold 44 pounds and resembles an Igloo cooler on wheels.

IMAGE CREDITS: CARTKEN

"Our food delivery robot started moving production samples around, and it's quickly turned into our busiest robot of all," Bersch said. "That's when we said, hey, there's like real use cases and real market need behind it, and that's when we started targeting that segment more and more."

At the time, Cartken was still pressing ahead on its delivery sidewalk business, including locking in [partnerships with Uber Eats](#) and GrubHub for its last-mile delivery operations across U.S. college campuses and in Japan.

But that early success with ZF encouraged the startup founders, which includes Jake Stelman, Jonas Witt, and Anjali Naik, to expand its business model. Switching Cartken's robots from food delivery to an industrial setting, wasn't much of a challenge, Bersch said. The AI behind the robots is trained on years of food delivery data and the devices are

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This means the robots can travel between indoor and outdoor settings. And thanks to data collected from delivering food on Tokyo streets, the robots are able to react and maneuver around obstacles.



IMAGE CREDITS: CARTKEN

Cartken, which has raised more than \$20 million from 468 Capital, Incubate Fund, Vela Partners, and other venture firms, has started to build out its robotic fleet to reflect its pivot to industrials. The company released the Cartken Hauler earlier this year, which is a larger version of the Cartken Courier and can hold up to 660 pounds. The company also released the Cartken Runner, designed for indoor deliveries, and is working on something similar to a robotic forklift.

“We have a navigation stack that is parameterizable for different robot sizes,” Bersch said. “All the AI and machine learning and training that went into that is like transferring directly to the other robots.”

Cartken recently announced that it was deepening its four-year relationship with Japanese automaker Mitsubishi, which originally helped the company get the needed certifications to operate their delivery robots on the streets of Tokyo.

Melco Mobility Solutions, a company under the Mitsubishi umbrella, just announced that it will be buying nearly [100 Cartken Hauler robots](#) for use in Japanese industrial facilities.

“We’re definitely seeing a lot of traction across various industrial and corporate sites, from automotive companies to pharmaceutical to chemical,” he said. “All these companies typically have people moving stuff from one building to another, whether it’s being by hand, on a cart, or a small forklift, and that is really what we’re targeting.”

Cartken will still continue its food and consumer last-mile delivery business, but it won’t be expanding it, Bersch said, adding they still do a lot of testing for new capabilities on these existing last-mile delivery routes.

This piece was corrected on July 21 to update that Cartken’s food delivery robots have six wheels not four.

Topics: [AI](#) [artificial intelligence](#) [Cartken](#) [delivery robots](#) [Japan](#)

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IMAGE CREDITS: CARTKEN

TRANSPORTATION



From burritos to biotech: How robotics startup Cartken found its AV niche

Kirsten Korosec — 7:00 AM PDT · July 3, 2024

Cartken and its diminutive sidewalk delivery robots first rolled into the world with a narrow charter: carrying everything from burritos and bento boxes to pizza and pad thai that last mile to hungry customers.

But the vision — thanks to the startup's approach to autonomous vehicle technology — was always broader, according to Cartken co-founder and CEO Christian Bersch. From its earliest days, Bersch and the rest of the founding team saw an opportunity for its robots to navigate the outdoor environment of pedestrian-filled sidewalks and the indoor world of factories, labs, industrial buildings and even airports.

The ability for a robot to move between indoors and outdoors seems simple enough. And yet, Bersch says it's not. It's here

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that Cartken and its 30-person team is carving out a niche in the ever-evolving autonomous vehicle industry.

Investors appear sold on the possibilities. Cartken has raised \$22.5 million in aggregate with \$10 million in its latest funding round led by 468 Capital, TechCrunch has exclusively learned. Incubate Fund, deep tech and AI funds LDV Partners and Vela Partners as well as strategic funds from Magna International, Mitsubishi Electric, Shell Ventures and Volex also participated.



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automotive campuses, including a factory operated by Germany-based [ZF](#). Some of that newly raised capital will be used to scale its more mature sidewalk delivery bot business, which Bersch said is profitable today. The bulk of the funds will be used to “unlock these new (indoor) use cases,” he added.

Cartken co-founder and COO [Anjali Jindal Naik](#) noted in a recent interview that they were surprised by the number of companies that have approached the startup in search of robots that can move between indoor and outdoor environments.

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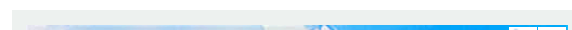
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“They’ve looked for other solutions, especially ones that go indoor and outdoor, and weren’t really finding them,” she added.

Cartken uses what it describes as a hardware agnostic AI-first approach to autonomy. What that means is a self-driving system that uses a camera-based system — no lidar — that uses AI models, trained on hundreds of thousands of images, to detect objects, as well as software algorithms to perceive and navigate the environment. Unlike some other outdoor robots used for delivery, Cartken isn’t reliant on GPS, allowing it to operate indoors. And the robots are made to handle sunlight and rain, pedestrians and uneven ground, all the requirements needed to handle outdoor environments. The self-driving system can also be transferred to different robot form factors and sizes.

The technology is much closer to what you would have in self-driving cars than what you would have in a traditional factory robot, according to Bersch.

In practice, the robots at the ZF factory carry parts that a human technician would previously shuttle via bicycle to other parts of the vast campus.

“That was time lost at the line, Bersch said, noting that it has translated to immediate savings. In 2023, Cartken robots operating at labs and factories in the biotech, pharmaceutical, chemical and automotive sectors saved

employees more than 10,000 hours in transportation,
according to the company.

Topics: [468 Capital](#) [autonomous delivery](#) [Cartken](#) [delivery robot](#)

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Google alum startup
Cartken and REEF
Technology launch Miami's
first delivery robots

Self-driving and robotics startup Cartken has partnered with REEF Technology, a startup that operates parking lots and neighborhood hubs, to bring self-driving delivery robots to the streets of downtown Miami.

With this announcement, Cartken officially comes out of stealth mode. The company—founded by ex-Google engineers and colleagues behind the unrequited Bookbot, was formed to develop market-ready tech in self-driving, AI-powered robotics and delivery operations in 2019, but the team has kept operations under wraps until now. This is Cartken's first large deployment of self-driving robots on sidewalks.

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IMAGE CREDITS: REEF TECHNOLOGIES

After a few test months, the REEF-branded electric-powered robots are now delivering dinner orders from REEF's network of delivery-only kitchens to people located within a 3/4-mile radius in downtown Miami. The robots, which are insulated and thus can preserve the heat of a plate of spaghetti or other hot food, are pre-stationed at designated logistics hubs and dispatched with orders for delivery as the food is prepared.

"We want to show how future-forward Miami can be," Matt Lindenberg, REEF's chief technology officer, told TechCrunch. "This is a great chance to show off the capabilities of the tech. The combination of us having a big presence in Miami, the fact that there are a lot of challenges around congestion as COVID subsides, still shows a really good environment where we can show how this tech can work."

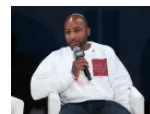
Lindenberg said Miami is a great place to start, but it's just the beginning, with potential for the Cartken robots to be used for REEF's other last-mile delivery businesses. Currently, only two restaurant delivery robots are operating in Miami, but Lindenberg said the company is planning to expand further

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into the city and outward into Fort Lauderdale, as well as other large metros the company operates in, such as Dallas, Atlanta, Los Angeles and eventually New York.

Lindenberger is hoping the presence of robots in the streets can act as a “force multiplier,” allowing them to scale while maintaining quality of service in a cost-effective way.

“We’re seeing an explosion in deliveries right now in a post-pandemic world and we foresee that to continue, so these types of no-contact, zero-emission automation techniques are really critical,” he said.

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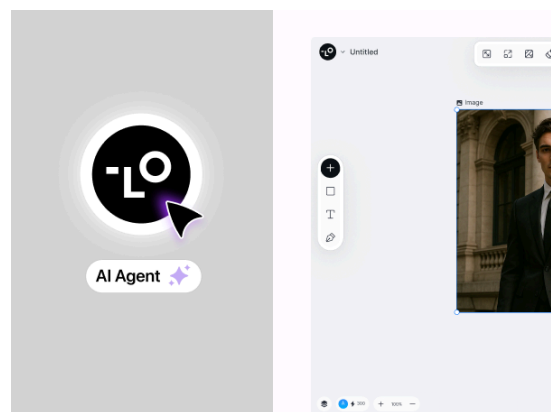
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[Starship Technologies CEO Lex Bayer on focus and opportunity in autonomous delivery](#)

Cartken’s robots are powered by a combination of machine learning and rules-based programming to react to every situation that could occur, even if that just means safely stopping and asking for help, Christian Bersch, CEO of Cartken, told TechCrunch. REEF would have supervisors on site to remotely control the robot if needed, a caveat that was included in the [2017 legislation that allowed for the operation of self-driving delivery robots in Florida](#).

“The technology at the end of the day is very similar to that of a self-driving car,” said Bersch. “The robot is seeing the environment, planning around obstacles like pedestrians or lampposts. If there’s an unknown situation, someone can help the robot out safely because it can stop on a dime. But

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it's important to also have that level of autonomy on the robot because it can react in a split second, faster than anybody remotely could, if something happens like someone jumps in front of it."

REEF marks specific operating areas on the map for the robots and Cartken tweaks the configuration for the city, accounting for specific situations a robot might need to deal with, so that when the robots are given a delivery address, they can make moves and operate like any other delivery driver. Only this driver has an LTE connection and is constantly updating its location so REEF can integrate it into its fleet management capabilities.



IMAGE CREDITS: REEF/CARTKEN

Eventually, Lindenberger said, they're hoping to be able to offer the option for customers to choose robot delivery on the major food delivery platforms REEF works with like Postmates, UberEats, DoorDash or GrubHub. Customers would receive a text when the robot arrives so they could go outside and meet it. However, the tech is not quite there yet.

Currently the robots only make it street-level, and then the food is passed off to a human who delivers it directly to the door, which is a service that most customers prefer. Navigating into an apartment complex and to a customer's unit is difficult for a robot to manage just yet, and many customers aren't quite ready to interact directly with a robot.

"It's an interim step, but this was a path for us to move forward quickly with the technology without having any other

boundaries,” said Lindenberger. “Like with any new tech, you want to take it in steps. So a super important step which we’ve now taken and works very well is the ability to dispatch robots within a certain radius and know that they’re going to arrive there. That in and of itself is a huge step and it allows us to learn what kind of challenges you have in terms of that very last step. Then we can begin to work with Cartken to solve that last piece. It’s a big step just being able to do this automation.”

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